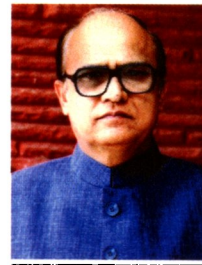


New Influenza A H1N1 (Swine Flu) – India Prepares

New Influenza A (H1N1) is a reassorted virus which originated in Mexico and has spread across the world causing a pandemic. Previous experiences with SARS and avian flu in this decade have helped in evolving preparedness plans across the globe including India. These plans are proving their value today when the H1N1 pandemic has started knocking at our doors and we have been able to contain the problem reasonably well.

This influenza pandemic, as per WHO estimates, may affect up to 1/3 of the world population, in view of lack of immunity human beings carry against this virus. National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA), Government of India along with Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoH & FW), took a leadership role in the preparedness for this pandemic, well in advance. A landmark meeting held in the year 2005 under the chairmanship of Hon'ble Home Minister with participation of NDMA, MoH & FW and Department of Animal Husbandry and Dairying led to the development of Contingency Plan for Management of Human Cases of Avian Influenza by Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoH & FW) in Dec 2005. This plan proved its efficacy while managing outbreaks of avian flu in Maharashtra and Gujarat in the year 2006 and later in Assam, Tripura, Mizoram and West Bengal in the year 2008.

These avian flu outbreaks warranted holistic preparedness including the business (work) continuity plan for non health sectors. NDMA in collaboration with United Nations Disaster Management Authority (UNDMT), Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA), Geneva and OCHA Regional Office for Asia Pacific (OCHAROAP) conducted an international workshop in April, 2008 in New Delhi. The deliberations, during this workshop, between officials from all ministries, NGO's and officials from all UN agencies located in India including WHO led to the release of a national document on



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"Pandemic Preparedness beyond Health" by the NDMA which was placed in public domain through NDMA website.

In April 2009, outbreak of Influenza A (H1N1) was declared in Mexico, leading to phase five global alert of pandemic by WHO. Being geared up for the action already, NDMA and MoH & FW released documents and guidelines suggesting various preventive and preparedness measures to contain the spread of pandemic. On the basis of these documents, crisis management plans were prepared for health and non-health sectors which were triggered into action on declaration of phase 6 of ongoing flu pandemic by WHO on 11th June 2009. This initiated important actions like entry screening at all entry points of immigration while taking adequate safety measures for the first responders. Collection of nasopharyngeal samples from suspected patients were started and dispatched to activated bio-safety laboratories for detecting and confirming the virus. Quarantine facilities were created for isolation of suspected patients and those who came in their contact, in earmarked hospitals, to halt the spread of the disease. Simultaneously, Integrated Disease

